International Baccalaureate Diploma Programme

Extended Essay

Portrayal of female characters in the novel Wuthering Heights

"*To what extent does Emily Brontë's portrayal of female characters in her novel Wuthering Heights indicate that she was a proto-feminist?*"

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Introduction

The novel *Wuthering Heights* was first published in 1847 and was written by the British author Emily Brontë. She was born July 30, 1818 in Thornton, a small village in West Yorkshire, England (Tompkins, 2020). Her novel tells the story of the love between the protagonists Heathcliff and Catherine Earnshaw and how their unfulfilled relationship affected their lives and their descendants' lives. Its main themes are love, passion and revenge. *Wuthering Heights* remains the only novel ever published by Emily Brontë due to her death of tuberculosis at the early age of thirty years (Tompkins, 2020).

Not only Emily Brontë but also her sisters Charlotte Brontë and Anne Brontë all published novels. They used male pseudonyms in order to avoid being looked on with prejudice, which indicates that they wanted women and men to be judged equally (Thormahlen, 1994). Writing was seen as an unladylike activity during their time. Ten years prior to Charlotte Brontë's publication of her novel *Jane Eyre*, she sent some of her poems to Robert Southey, a poet laureate whose response was that "Literature cannot be the business of a woman's life, and it ought not to be. The more she is engaged in her proper duties, the less leisure she will have for it even as an accomplishment and a recreation" (Buzwell, 2020). The Brontë sisters' true identities were later revealed and their work received a lot of attention.

While feminist analysis on literature often focuses on *Jane Eyre* by Charlotte Brontë, the novel *Wuthering Heights* is often considered to be proto-feminist as well (Grady, 2017). Since the book was written during the Victorian era, gender roles differed significantly from the ones we have today. Throughout the novel, there is a strong emphasis on gender roles and the ways women have been oppressed. While it features strong female characters, they face abuse by one of the main characters, Heathcliff, and fight for their standing in society in various ways. This is still a very relevant and global topic since women are being oppressed to this day.

In an attempt to analyze the feminism of the novel from a new perspective and focus exclusively on *Wuthering Heights* by Emily Brontë, this essay is dedicated to the portrayal of female characters in the novel. Thus, this essay will include an analysis of the female image during the Victorian era and how the female author Emily Brontë conveyed gender roles in her work. Therefore, *Wuthering Heights* by Emily Brontë will function as the primary resource, while there will be secondary resources included, which are mainly used for the research of gender roles in Victorian England. While the concept of feminism was still unknown during the time the novel was written, this essay emphasizes the historical context and may certify whether or not the author Emily Brontë introduced feminist ideas in her writing, by following the research question: "To what extent does Emily Brontë's portrayal of female characters in her novel Wuthering Heights indicate that she was a proto-feminist?"

Female Education in Victorian England

Early in the novel, the protagonist Catherine Earnshaw is described as being a very smart and intelligent young girl:

> "[Heathcliff] struggled long to keep up an equality with Catherine in her studies". (Brontë, 1847; Chapter VIII)

Catherine was more educated than Heathcliff, which was unusual during the time the novel was written. In Victorian England, girls just started receiving childhood education. At that time, they were still not entitled to high educational attainment and they only had access to education as long as their parents had the financial capabilities necessary (Dearnley, 2020). Catherine's daughter Catherine "Cathy" Linton was just as determined as her mother was in her studies. By describing the female characters as being so diligent, Emily Brontë demonstrated that girls were just as capable of learning as boys. Additionally, she

demonstrated how the environment of the child plays a significant role in the child's development. Cathy had a good relationship with her father Edgar Linton and her servant Nelly Dean and was well supported in being an educated child. She spent a lot of time in their estate's library, just like her father did, and was really passionate about books. Her cousin Hareton Earnshaw, on the other hand, did not receive a lot of attention from his father Hindley Earnshaw and was only tolerated by his uncle Heathcliff. Therefore, he did not have access to any form of education. Due to his lack of education he was illiterate until Cathy developed a good relationship with him and taught him how to read. By doing this, Emily Brontë creates another relationship in which the woman is more educated than the man is, just like Catherine and Heathcliff. This contrasts significantly with how social constructs appeared at the time and reverses gender roles.

Catherine's and Cathy's willingness to educate themselves and Cathy even teaching her cousin how to read, show how they do not fit into the typical female image of the Victorian era. The only thing expected of women in society during that time was for them to be able to take care of the household and be a mother (Allingham, n.d.). The social construct of the Victorian era taught girls that only boys needed higher education because girls were educated in more "fashionable" subjects and were only taught "accomplishments" that would help them find a husband like, for example, having artistic talents such as singing and dancing ("Education in Victorian England", n.d.). Because women were not able to have their own freedom in how they wanted to be educated, knowledge was a sort of power for women to hold, since it was not a matter of course. However, women were only allowed to go to college starting in 1869, when nine women were admitted to the University of London, which was a very important event in the history of feminism (Dearnley, 2020). The fact that Emily Brontë portrayed her female characters as smart and self-educated indicates that she did have a very feministic view and vision of how girls should really be educated and that she wanted women

and men to be treated equally. According to that, her idea on how education should really be fits more into the system we mostly have in developed countries today, where both girls and boys have equal access to all types of education. However, gender inequality is still a very big problem in many countries around the world and less than half of all countries have achieved gender parity in primary education (*Girls' education,* 2020).

Female Dependence on Men and Social Status

The era in which the novel is written also reflects Catherine's choice of marrying Edgar instead of her true love Heathcliff. Although she did have feelings for Edgar, Catherine still felt that Heathcliff was her soulmate and her love for Edgar was not the same, as she explained to her servant Nelly Dean shortly after the engagement:

> "It would degrade me to marry Heathcliff now; so he shall never know how I love him: and that, not because he's handsome, Nelly, but because he's more myself than I am. Whatever our souls are made of, his and mine are the same; and Linton's is as different as a moonbeam from lightning, or frost from fire" (Brontë, 1847; Chapter IX)

Her decision might not be as sympathizable in this day and age, but during the Victorian era, women still depended a lot on their husbands and marriage (Hughes, 2014). Catherine describes a potential marriage to Heathcliff as "degrading", which underlines the fact that in order to be socially relevant, women had to marry a man of higher social status. Catherine knew that Edgar could give her the life that Heathcliff could not, so she got engaged to Edgar Linton. This indicates that social status was very important to the people during the Victorian

era and Catherine feared that if she were to marry Heathcliff, they would have been poor their whole lives, which she explained to Nelly Dean:

> "Nelly, I see now you think of me a selfish wretch; but did it never strike you that if Heathcliff and I married, we should be beggars?" (Brontë, 1847; Chapter IX)

The reason for this is that at the beginning of the novel, Catherine's father visits Liverpool and adopts Heathcliff, at the time a starving orphan, which is why Heathcliff was never accepted as being from the same social class as the Earnshaws. Other family members from the Earnshaw family hardly accepted Heathcliff and eventually, after Mr. Earnshaw's death, Catherine was his only true friend that he looked up to. There were also signs of racial exclusion in *Wuthering Heights* as Mr. Lockwood describes Heathcliff as a "dark-skinned gypsy" (Brontë, 1847; Chapter I). Edgar, on the other hand, was already born into a wealthy family, and marrying him was the safer choice for Catherine in order to be socially relevant. By marrying Edgar, Catherine lived in a high social class and they were very respectful to each other during their blissful marriage. He let Catherine be part of his aristocracy and let her move into his estate Thrushcross Grange.

Emily Brontë then creates a different situation with Isabella Linton's marriage to Heathcliff. Because Catherine did not marry Heathcliff, he departed from the family for three years. When he came back he manipulated Isabella, Edgar's little sister, and only married her out of revenge on Edgar and Catherine. Although Catherine understood his intentions from the start and warned him, Heathcliff went on with his plan. Isabella fell for him; he was a handsome young man at the time and found a way to build wealth during the three years he had been away from Wuthering Heights. He managed to convince Isabella to leave Thrushcross Grange which harmed the relationship between Isabella and her brother Edgar significantly. She later regrets her decision of marrying Heathcliff due to him being abusive

towards her during their marriage. She flees from her husband while being pregnant with his son, which was a controversial decision at that time considering that women in that situation would have been heavily criticized. During the Victorian era, women were not allowed to get a divorce in a marriage (Stoker, 2020). Additionally, women were meant to be respectful towards their husbands. However, after Isabella decided to leave Heathcliff, she did not bother to be respectful towards him and even seemed to find enjoyment in destroying her wedding ring, as seen in her dialog with Nelly Dean after running away:

> " '[...]We parted unreconciled, you remember, and I sha'n't forgive myself. But, for all that, I was not going to sympathise with him – the brute beast! [...] 'I'll smash [the wedding ring]!' she continued, striking it with childish spite, 'and then I'll burn it!' and she took and dropped the misused article among the coals." (Brontë, 1847; Chapter XVII)

By choosing to leave her abusive husband, Isabella fought for her own freedom of starting a new life. This shows how female dependence on their husbands oppressed women by taking part of their freedom, even when they were facing abuse like Isabella did. Isabella then moved far away and raised their son Linton Earnshaw on her own until she died. Her son was perfectly healthy until her death, which was unusual for children that were raised only by their mother, since women only made about half of the wages that men did, so it was very hard for them to provide for a child (Richardson, 2014). The gender pay gap is still a very significant matter all around the world. On average, women make only 77 cents for every dollar earned by a man and there is not a single country in the world that has yet achieved income parity (van der Straaten et al., 2020).

Female Behavior and Stereotypes

The female characters Catherine and her daughter Cathy often stand out in the novel by the way they behave. In Victorian England, girls and women were expected to be loving and caring (Jeffers, 2016). However, the two were often represented as rebellious and played the dominant role in a lot of their relationships. Nelly Dean explained that when Catherine and Heathcliff were young, they "both promised fair to grow up as rude as savages" (Brontë, 1847; Chapter VI). This shows how both Catherine and Heathcliff were aware of how they behaved and that they did it intentionally. Catherine already had a difficult time fitting into the stereotypical notion of a girl when she was young. From an early age, she chose whom she loved and was very energetic, demanding constant attention from those around her. Nelly Dean describes her as an unusual child, that was hard to bring under control:

> "Certainly she has ways with her such as I never saw a child take up before; and she put all of us past our patience fifty times and oftener in a day: from the hour she came down-stairs till the hour she went to bed, we had not a minute's security that she wouldn't be in mischief." (Brontë, 1847; Chapter V)

Until Catherine started spending time with Edgar Linton as she got older, she was never concerned about manners and Nelly's description of her remained accurate. After getting to know him and his family better, she stayed at their estate Thrushcross Grange for five weeks. They were of higher social status and taught Catherine new manners that fit the past expectations of a girl's behavior in Victorian England:

> "[Mrs. Linton] visited [Catherine] often in the interval, and commenced her plan of reform by trying to raise her self-respect with fine clothes and flattery, which she took readily; so that instead of a wild savage jumping

> into the house, and rushing to squeeze us all breathless, there 'lighted from a handsome black pony a very dignified person [...]." (Brontë, 1847; Chapter VII)

This part of the novel gives further information about how Victorian perceptions of ideal women really were. It demonstrates that a girl as demanding and wild as Catherine was not desired by society as she is described as "a wild savage" (Brontë, 1847; Chapter VII). Instead, girls were meant to behave and look elegant and neat. Catherine was expected to wear fine clothes and to always be "dignified", as Nelly described (Brontë, 1847; Chapter VII). Additionally, according to this part of the novel, acting dignified was seen as a way to gain self-respect.

From that point on Catherine Earnshaw was considered an ideal Victorian woman, who later married into a good family and cared about her standing in society. But although she was willing to adapt the new manners, Catherine struggled to keep up the exemplary behavior at the start. When Nelly did something that was not in accordance with her will, she "stamped her foot, wavered a moment, and then, irresistibly impelled by the naughty spirit within her, slapped [Nelly Dean] on the cheek"(Brontë, 1847; Chapter VIII). Through this part of the novel, Emily Brontë conveys that Catherine is not her true self when acting with her newly learned manners. Whenever she acted the way she was taught to, it was just pretense and when acting impulsively, she acted just like she did before her visit at Thrushcross Grange. Catherine later regrets her decision of marrying Edgar instead of Heathcliff, which can be seen in the way she talks to Heathcliff shortly before her death by expressing her regret and pleading for forgiveness:

> "I'm not wishing you greater torment than I have, Heathcliff. I only wish us never to be parted: and should a word of mine distress you hereafter, think I

> feel the same distress underground, and for my own sake, forgive me!" (Brontë, 1847; Chapter XV)

Although Catherine was more socially relevant, she was not truly happy with the way she had spent her life living after the expectations of a woman from society that she had adapted.

Shortly before Catherine's death, her daughter Catherine "Cathy" Linton was born. Although Cathy was not raised by her mother but rather by her father Edgar Linton and her servant Nelly Dean, both characters show a few similarities in their behavior. Cathy and her mother are two very strong female characters in this novel, however, Cathy is not as demanding as Catherine was, according to how Nelly Dean described her:

> "That capacity for intense attachments reminded me of her mother: still she did not resemble her: for she could be soft and mild as a dove, and she had a gentle voice and pensive expression: her anger was never furious; her love never fierce: it was deep and tender." (Brontë, 1847; Chapter XVIII)

Cathy lives happily with her father at Thrushcross Grange until she suddenly experiences Heathcliff's manipulative abuse as others did before. He manages to force her to marry his son, Linton Earnshaw. Although Heathcliff seems to be an intimidating character, she is not afraid of him and stays resistant. When Heathcliff holds both Cathy and Nelly hostage, she fights back by "applying her teeth pretty sharply" (Brontë, 1847; Chapter XXVII) onto his muscles. Her behavior proves the strength of her character and what a strong-minded person she really is. Not all characters dared to take action against Heathcliff's abuse which is demonstrated by the relationship between Heathcliff and his son, Linton. When Nelly Dean and Cathy arranged a meeting with Linton, Nelly Dean felt like the young boy was being restrained by his father's will:

> "Linton had sunk prostrate again in another paroxysm of helpless fear, caused by his father's glance towards him, I suppose: there was nothing else to produce such humiliation." (Brontë, 1847; Chapter XXVII)

By depicting Cathy as more fearless towards Heathcliff compared to Linton, Emily Brontë reverses gender roles once again, since women were seen as physically and emotionally weaker than men (Allingham, n.d.). Linton has more character traits that would have been considered feminine, by constantly complaining and expecting other people's efforts. He is described as having a "sickly peevishness" (Brontë, 1847; Chapter XIX) while Cathy has more characteristics that would have been considered masculine, for example the ability to hold her own in a fight. At the end of the novel, Cathy does not repeat her mother's mistake and marries her true love, Hareton Earnshaw, despite him being from a lower social class than her. As a matter of fact, she did not need to marry a man of higher social standing in order to be socially relevant since Cathy Linton became the owner of the two estates Wuthering Heights and Thrushcross Grange after her father's and Heathcliff's death, which secured her independence.

Using Isabella Linton's character, Emily Brontë contrasts the behavior of Catherine and Cathy with that of a Victorian ideal woman. Although Isabella did not fit into the stereotypes of a Victorian woman after escaping Heathcliff's abuse, she was raised according to the expectations of a female during that time and came from a really wealthy family. When she was first introduced in the novel, she met Catherine and Heathcliff, when they were all still children. However, she was very dismissive towards Heathcliff at the time and described him as a "frightful thing" (Brontë, 1847; Chapter VI). Later she appears more frequently in the novel, as she starts living at Thrushcross Grange with her older brother Edgar and his wife Catherine. Nelly describes her as "a charming young lady of eighteen; infantile in manners, though possessed of keen wit, keen feelings, and a keen temper, too, if irritated"(Brontë,

1847; Chapter X). Isabella's love for Heathcliff had made her seem more vulnerable since she fell for him despite Catherine's and Edgar's warnings and she also seems to stay in the shadow of Catherine's strong personality.

Conclusion

The novel *Wuthering Heights* by Emily Brontë can be considered feminist although it was written before the concept of feminism was generally known. The author portrayed her female characters as outstanding and often gave them what would have been considered "masculine" characteristics. By doing this, she displays that gender does not determine someone's behavior. She included a lot of characters and situations that indicate that she had feminist views. She demonstrated her feminist views by challenging gender roles as she criticized the female dependence on men by making Isabella Linton escape Heathcliff's abuse, made her female characters very educated, and made them not fit into society's ideas of an ideal Victorian woman. Ultimately, she created female characters that went against society's norms. The strengths of Catherine's and Cathy's characters, particularly their imperious will, indicate how important it was for her to oppose gender roles at the time. Whilst Emily Brontë practices de-stereotyping by making her female characters challenge gender roles, she makes them deal with cycles of abuse, mainly by Heathcliff. She shows how gender roles can be reversed, while Cathy is more educated than Hindley and more fearless towards Heathcliff than Linton.

Since women and men are still not treated equally in many aspects and many parts of the world, feminism remains a very active and relevant movement. At the same time, there is an Anti-Feminism movement of people who believe that society has already achieved gender equality and that feminism has now become unnecessary. However, studies have shown that

gender biases still have a huge effect on people's mindsets, even if only subconsciously (Harvind, 2022). For example, people still often connect smartness to the male gender, which is also one of the topics that Emily Brontë addressed in *Wuthering Heights*.

Sources of proto-feminism such as the novel *Wuthering Heights* by Emily Brontë represent the origin of feminism and demonstrate how far the movement has come within two centuries. By analyzing the inequality issues of today's society, it is clear that the feminist themes Emily Brontë brought up in the 19th century can still be applied to our society today. In conclusion, the novel Wuthering Heights can be classified as proto-feminist and also continues to be frequently analyzed and talked about.

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